Find Your Way Around

THE FREEDAWM GUIDE



ONE PAGE, ONE IDEA:
CHEAT SHEETS FOR RECORDING, EDITING AND MIXING

FreeDAWm

Welcome to FreeDAWm

A free, open-source studio for recording, editing and mixing music, on the computer you already have.

FreeDAWm is a digital audio workstation. It runs on macOS, Windows, Linux and FreeBSD, and in a web browser.

You work in two main windows. The **Edit** window is the timeline, where you record, cut and arrange. The **Mix** window is the mixer, where you balance and shape the sound.

This guide is a binder of cheat sheets, not a manual to read from start to finish. Each page covers one idea, and most are a picture with labels.

Keep the page you need open beside FreeDAWm, or print it and pin it up.

HOW TO READ A SHEET

- The lettered dots on a picture match the lettered notes under it.
- Keys look like this: `Cmd` `S`. Hold the first, press the second.
- On Windows, Linux and FreeBSD, press `Ctrl` wherever a sheet says `Cmd`.
- Menu items are written as a path: Setup › Keyboard Shortcuts.

Most pictures show a short rock session: drums, bass, guitars and a stack of vocals. A few show **Midnight Groove**, the demo song that comes with FreeDAWm.

Contents

Section 1: Getting Around

The Edit Window 5
The Mix Window 6
Edit Modes & Tools 7
Keyboard Shortcuts 8

Section 2: Recording

Set Up Your Sound 10
Inputs & New Tracks 11
Record a Take 12
Punch, Loop & Comp 13

Section 3: Editing

Cut, Move & Tidy 15
Fades & Crossfades 16
Markers & Moving Around 17

Section 4: MIDI & Instruments

The MIDI Editor 19
Editing Notes 20
Juke: The Kit 21
Juke: Patterns 22
Lift: The Sampler 23

Section 5: Vocals

Tune a Vocal 25
Tuning Moves 26
The Vocal Studio 27

Section 6: Mixing

Signal Flow 29
Add an Effect 30
Inside an Effect 31
The FireStation Effects 32
The Plugin Browser 33
Sends & Shared Reverb 34
Automation 35

Section 7: AI Tools

The AI Menu 37
Run an AI Tool 38
Set Up the AI Models 39

Section 8: Finishing

Bounce the Mix 41
Other Ways Out 42

Section 9: Menu Map

FreeDAWm, File & Setup 44
Edit Menu 45
View & Clip 46
Track Menu 47
Event & Options 48
Process & AI 49
Window Menu 50

Glossary

Glossary 51

SECTION 1

Getting Around

The two windows you will spend your time in, the four ways clips can move, and the keys worth learning first.

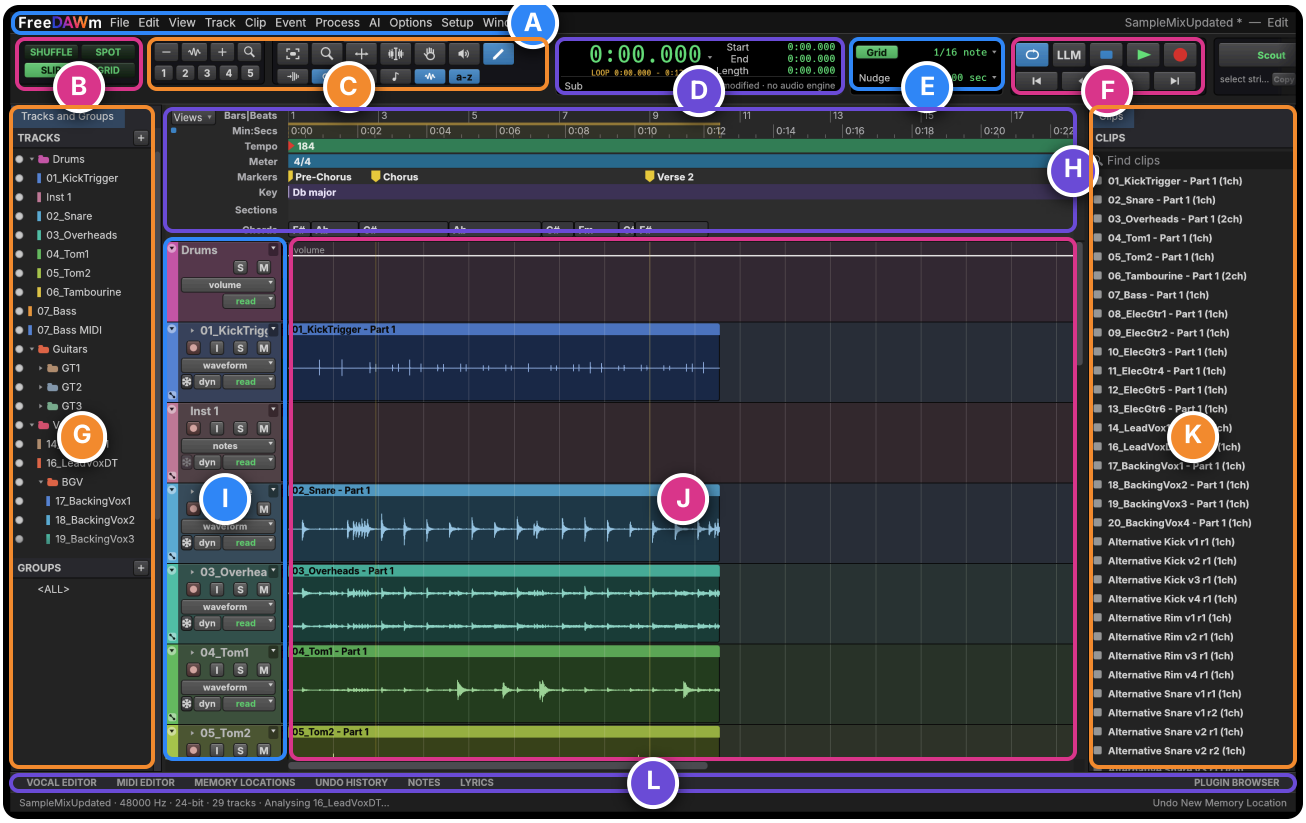
FreeDAWm

FreeDAWm

THE EDIT WINDOW

The Goal

Know what each part of the timeline window is for, so you can find a control without hunting. Open it with Window › Edit, or press Cmd = to flip between Edit and Mix.



A — Menu bar
Every command lives here. If you forget a key, look in the menus.

B — Edit modes
Shuffle, Slip, Spot and Grid decide how clips move when you drag them. See page 7.

C — Zoom and tools
Zoom buttons and five zoom presets, then the editing tools. See page 7.

D — Counter
Where the cursor is, and the start, end and length of your selection.

E — Grid and Nudge
The size of a grid step and of a nudge. Nudge with + and −.

F — Transport
Loop, stop, play and record on top, and the buttons that jump or wind underneath.

G — Tracks and Groups
Every track in the song. Click the dot beside a name to show or hide that track.

H — Rulers
Time in bars and in minutes, then tempo, meter, markers, key and chords.

I — Track controls
Record, input monitor (I), solo (S) and mute (M), then the track's view and automation mode.

J — Timeline
Your clips. Audio is drawn as waveforms and MIDI as notes. Time runs left to right.

K — Clips list
Every clip in the session. Type in Find clips to search it.

L — Panel tabs
Click a tab to open the Vocal Editor, MIDI Editor, Undo History and more.

FreeDAWm

THE MIX WINDOW

The Goal

Read a channel strip from top to bottom. Sound enters at the top of a strip and leaves at the fader, so the order on screen is the order the sound travels.



A **Transport and counter**
The same play, stop and record controls as the Edit window.

B **Channel width**
Slim strips fit more on screen. Wide strips show each effect's knobs.

C **Effects**
FireStation modules such as Shale and Transient, processed from top to bottom. Click + to add one.

D **Sends**
Slots a to e each send a copy of the track somewhere else, often to a shared reverb.

E **I/O**
Where the track's sound comes from and goes to, then its automation mode.

F **Group and pan**
The knob places the sound left or right. Stereo tracks get one knob per side.

G **Strip buttons**
Input monitor, record and freeze, then solo (S) and mute (M).

H **Fader and meter**
The fader sets the track's level. The meter beside it shows how loud it is.

I **Level and name**
The fader's value in dB, the track type, and the track name.

J **Folder input**
Drums is a folder track. It takes its sound from the Drums Bus, which every drum track feeds.

Good to know

The list on the left is the same Tracks and Groups list as in the Edit window. The coloured bar under each name matches that track's clips on the timeline.

FreeDAWm

EDIT MODES & TOOLS

The Goal

The edit mode decides where a clip lands when you move it. The tool decides what a click or drag does. Pick both before you edit.

THE FOUR EDIT MODES

BY HAND

Slip
F2 or Alt+2



Clips go exactly where you drop them. Gaps and overlaps are allowed. This is the mode FreeDAWm starts in.

Shuffle
F1 or Alt+1



Clips close up end to end. Cut a piece out and everything after it slides left to fill the gap.

Spot
F3 or Alt+3



FreeDAWm asks for an exact position, and the clip goes there. Use it when you know the time and not the place.

Grid
F4 or Alt+4



Clips and selections jump to the nearest grid line. Press F4 again for Relative Grid, which keeps a clip's offset from the line.

STAYS WHERE YOU PUT IT

SNAPS INTO PLACE

BY THE CLOCK

Left and right: does the clip stay where you put it, or does FreeDAWm line it up for you?

Up and down: do you place it by hand, or by a time on the ruler?

THE TOOLS

- F5 **Zoomer** — Drag across an area to zoom in on it.
- F6 **Trim** — Drag a clip's edge to make it shorter or longer.
- F7 **Selector** — Click to place the cursor. Drag to select a range.
- F8 **Grabber** — Drag a clip to move it.
- F9 **Scrubber** — Drag over audio to hear it under the pointer.
- F10 **Pencil** — Draw notes and automation.

Smart Tool

Press F6 and F7 together for three tools in one. Near a clip's edge it trims, in the upper half of a clip it selects, and in the lower half it grabs.

FreeDAWm

KEYBOARD SHORTCUTS

The Goal

Learn these first. They cover most of a session, and each one saves a trip to the menus. On Windows, Linux and FreeBSD, press Ctrl wherever you see Cmd.

PLAY AND RECORD

Play or stop	Space
Record	F12 or Cmd Space
Play at half speed	Shift Space
Back to the start	Home
Go to the end	End
Add a marker	Enter
Loop playback on or off	Cmd Shift L
Play the selection	Alt [

TRACKS

New track	Cmd Shift N
Record enable	Shift R
Solo	Shift S
Mute	Shift M
Input monitoring	Shift I
Group tracks	Cmd G

SESSION

New session	Cmd N
Open a session	Cmd O
Save	Cmd S
Save as	Cmd Shift S
Import audio	Cmd Shift I
Bounce the mix to a file	Cmd Alt B

EDITING

Undo	Cmd Z
Redo	Cmd Shift Z
Cut, copy, paste	Cmd X C V
Duplicate	Cmd D
Select all	Cmd A
Split at the selection	Cmd E
Heal a split	Cmd H
Trim to the selection	Cmd T
Create fades	Cmd F
Mute a clip	Cmd M
Clear the selection	Cmd B or Delete
Nudge later or earlier	+ −

ZOOM AND VIEW

Zoom out or in	R T
Fit the whole session	Alt A
Zoom to the selection	Alt F
Zoom toggle	E
Jump to the next clip edge	Tab
Switch between Mix and Edit	Cmd =
Edit modes	F1 to F4
Tools	F5 to F10

Make them yours

Change any shortcut in Setup › Keyboard Shortcuts. A few keys are fixed, including Space, Enter, Tab and the F keys.

SECTION 2

Recording

Get sound into FreeDAWm: choose your audio device, make a track, record a take, and fix the part that went wrong without redoing the rest.

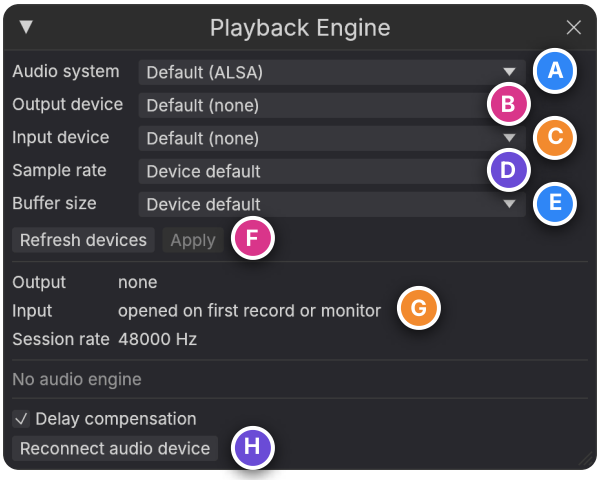
FreeDAWm

FreeDAWm

SET UP YOUR SOUND

The Goal

Tell FreeDAWm which device to play through and record from. You do this once per device, in Setup › Playback Engine.



A — Audio system
How FreeDAWm talks to your sound hardware. Leave it on Default unless your interface needs another.

B — Output device
Where you hear the mix: your interface, speakers or headphones.

C — Input device
Where recordings come from: your interface or a microphone.

D — Sample rate
The detail of the sound. Device default is a safe choice.

E — Buffer size
How much sound is handled at a time. See below.

F — Refresh and Apply
Refresh after you plug something in. Apply makes your choices take effect.

G — Status
What is open right now, and the session's sample rate.

H — Reconnect
Click this if the sound stops after a device was unplugged.

BUFFER SIZE: A TRADE

SMALL — LARGE

Small buffer

You hear yourself with almost no delay, but the computer works harder and may crackle. Best while recording.

Large buffer

Steady playback with lots of effects, but a delay you can hear when you play or sing. Best while mixing.

Good to know

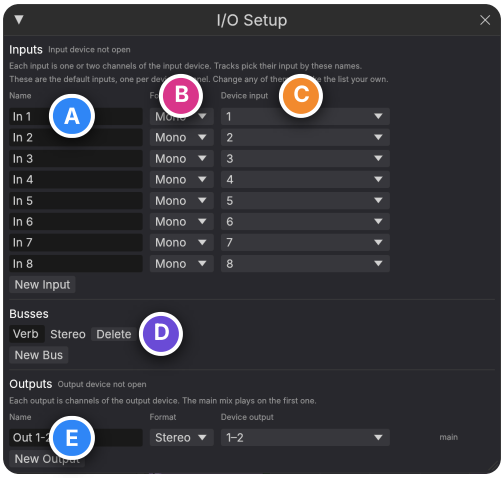
On the picture the input reads "opened on first record or monitor". FreeDAWm only opens your microphone when you arm a track or turn on monitoring.

FreeDAWm

INPUTS & NEW TRACKS

The Goal

Give your inputs names you will recognise, then make a track to record on. Named inputs save you from guessing which socket is which.



A **Input names**
Open Setup › I/O and type over a name: Vocal Mic, Guitar DI. Tracks pick their input by these names.

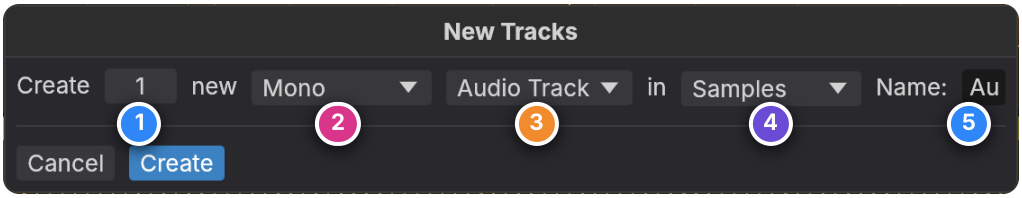
B **Format**
Mono is one channel, for a single mic or cable. Stereo is a pair.

C **Device input**
Which socket on your interface this name stands for.

D **Busses**
Paths inside FreeDAWm, used to send several tracks to one place.

E **Outputs**
Where sound leaves. The main mix plays on the first one.

MAKE A TRACK



Track › New, or Cmd Shift N

1 **How many**
Make several tracks in one go.

2 **Mono or stereo**
Match the input you will record.

3 **Track type**
See the table below.

4 **Samples or ticks**
Ticks make clips follow tempo changes.

5 **Name**
Name it now. Recordings take the track's name.

Audio Track	Records and plays sound: a voice, a guitar, a drum mic.
Instrument Track	Plays a software instrument from the notes you record or draw.
MIDI Track	Holds notes only, to drive an instrument somewhere else.
Aux Input	Has no clips. It takes sound from a bus, often for a shared reverb.
Master Fader	Controls the level of an output, usually the whole mix.

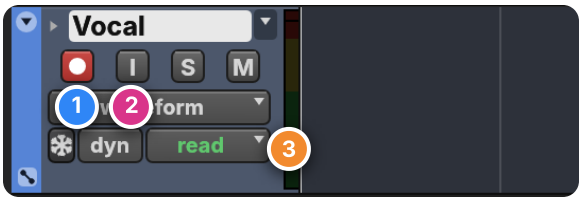
FreeDAWm

RECORD A TAKE

The Goal

Record your first take in six steps. The first three happen on the track, the last three on the transport.

ON THE TRACK

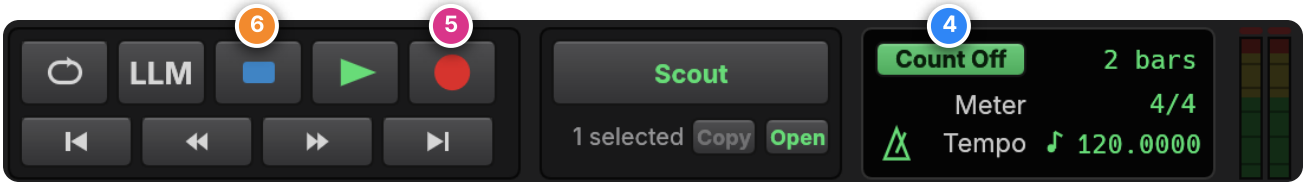


1. **Arm the track**
   Click its record button so it lights red, or select the track and press Shift R.

2. **Hear yourself**
   Click I to monitor the input through the track, effects included. Shift I does the same.

3. **Check the level**
   Play or sing your loudest part and watch the meter. Turn the input down on your interface if it reaches the red at the top.

ON THE TRANSPORT



4. **Count yourself in**
   Click Count Off to hear two bars of click before the take starts.

5. **Record**
   Click the red button, or press F12 or Cmd Space.

6. **Stop**
   Press Space. Your take appears as a clip on the track.

ALSO ON THE TRANSPORT

Metronome	The icon beside Tempo turns the click on or off during the take.
LLM	Low Latency Monitoring. It bypasses the effects that add delay on the tracks you are recording.
Loop	Plays the selection round and round. See the next page for recording in a loop.
Tempo and Meter	Set these before you record to a click. Drag the tempo, or click it to type a number.

Not happy?

Press Cmd Z to undo the take, then record again. FreeDAWm autosaves as you work and can recover a session after a crash.

FreeDAWm

PUNCH, LOOP & COMP

The Goal

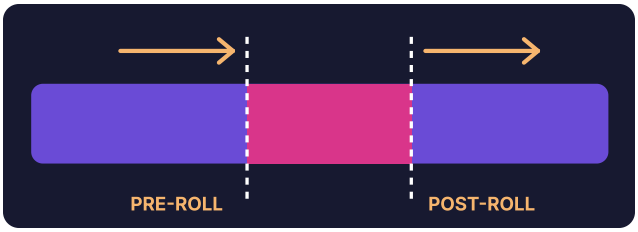
Fix one line without redoing the song, record several tries in a row, and build one good take from the best parts of each.



Punch in

Select the part you want to redo, then record. Only the selection is replaced. Everything around it stays.

No selection? Press Record while the song plays to drop in at that moment.



Pre-roll and post-roll

Turn on Options › Pre/Post-Roll, or press Cmd K. Playback starts a little before the punch so you can play along into it, and carries on a little after.



Loop record

Turn on Options › Loop Record, or press Alt L. Select the bars to repeat and record. Each time round makes a new take, so you can keep trying without stopping.



Comp the best parts

Click the small arrow before the track name to show its take layers. Drag across the part of a take you like and it is copied up into the track, with a short crossfade at each join.

SECTION 3

Editing

Shape what you recorded: cut and move clips, smooth the joins with fades, and find your way round a long song.

FreeDAWm

FreeDAWm

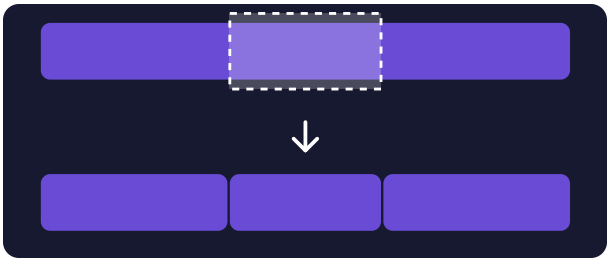
CUT, MOVE & TIDY

The Goal

Six edits do most of the work. Each one acts on the selection, so select first: drag across a clip with the Selector, or click once to place the cursor.

Split

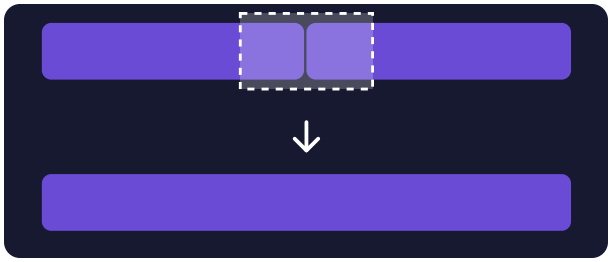
Cmd E



Cuts the clip at both edges of the selection. With only a cursor, it cuts once.

Heal

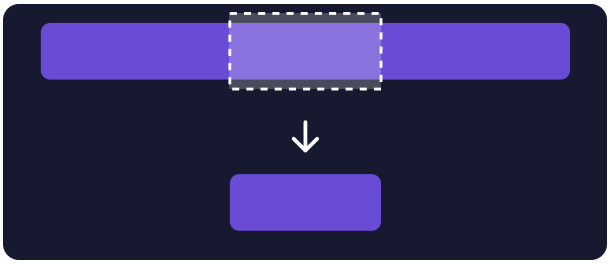
Cmd H



Select across a cut and heal it. The two pieces become one clip again.

Trim to selection

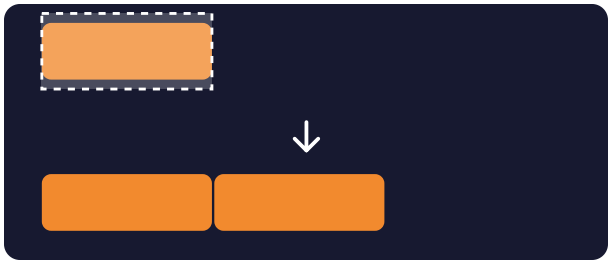
Cmd T



Keeps the selected part of the clip and removes the rest.

Duplicate

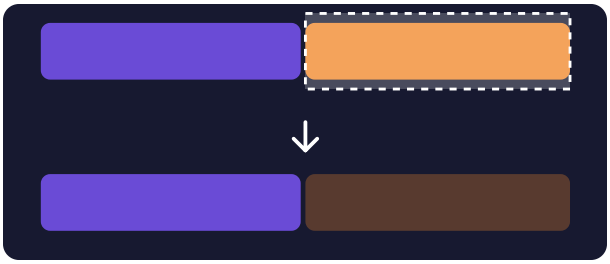
Cmd D



Places a copy straight after the selection. Press it again for another.

Mute

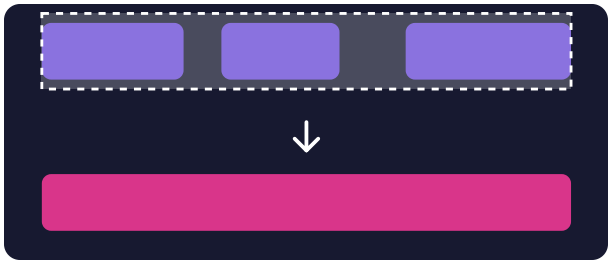
Cmd M



The clip stays where it is but makes no sound. Press again to bring it back.

Consolidate

Alt Shift 3



Turns the selection, gaps included, into one new clip.

Good to know

These edits change clips, not your recordings. To get trimmed sound back, drag the clip's edge out again with the Trim tool. Cmd Z undoes any of them.

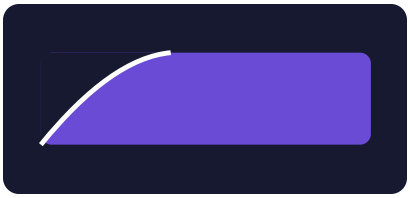
FreeDAWm

FADES & CROSSFADES

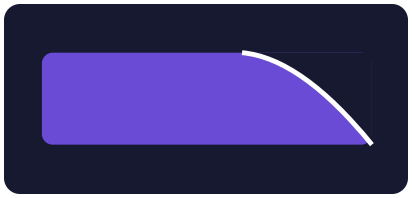
The Goal

A cut that lands in the middle of a sound can click. A fade ramps the level so the join is smooth. Put one on every edit you can hear.

THREE KINDS



Fade in
Select from before a clip's start to where the sound should be at full level.



Fade out
Select from where the fade should begin to past the clip's end.

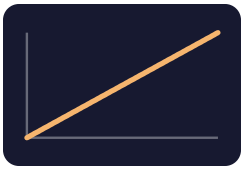


Crossfade
Select across the join between two clips. One fades out as the other fades in.

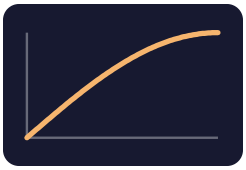
MAKE ONE

1. **Select**
   Drag across the start, the end or the join, as shown above.
2. **Create**
   Press Cmd F, or choose Edit › Fades › Create.
3. **Pick a shape**
   Choose one of the five below and click OK.

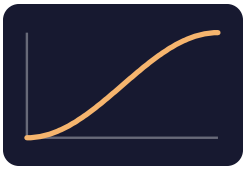
FIVE SHAPES



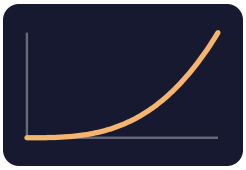
Linear
A straight ramp.



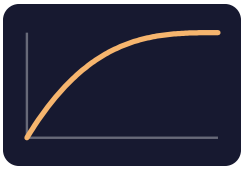
Equal Power
Keeps a crossfade's level steady. The usual choice.



S-Curve
Gentle at both ends.



Exponential
Starts slowly, then rises fast.



Logarithmic
Rises fast, then eases in.

Each curve shows the level of a fade in, from silence on the left to full on the right. A fade out is the mirror image.

Faster

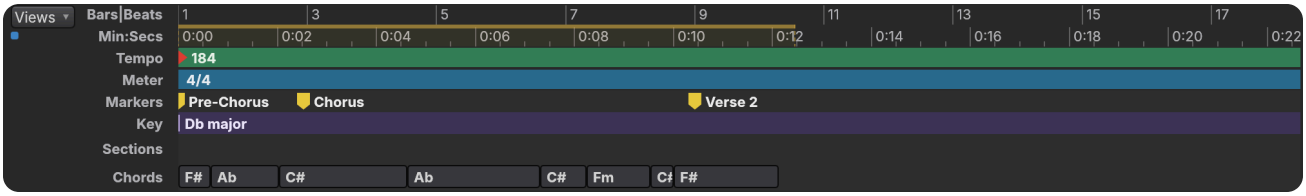
With the Smart Tool, drag from the top corner of a clip to draw a fade by hand. Edit › Fades › Delete removes the fades in the selection.

FreeDAWm

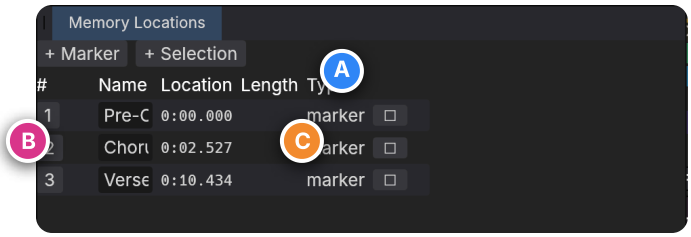
MARKERS & MOVING AROUND

The Goal

Label the parts of your song once, then jump between them. A few keys cover the rest: zooming, stepping from clip to clip, and nudging.



Markers show as flags on the Markers ruler, above the key and the chords.



A **+ Marker and + Selection**
Marker stores the cursor's place. Selection stores the selected range. Enter also adds a marker.

B **Number**
Type . then the number then . to jump to that location.

C **Name and location**
What you called it and where it sits in the song.

Window › Memory Locations, or the Memory Locations tab at the bottom of the Edit window

ZOOM

Zoom out or in	R T
Fit the whole session	Alt A
Zoom to the selection	Alt F
Zoom toggle	E
Taller waveforms	Cmd Alt]
Recall a zoom preset	Click 1 to 5
Store a zoom preset	Cmd-click 1 to 5

MOVE AND NUDGE

Start or end of the session	Home End
Next clip edge	Tab
Previous clip edge	Alt Tab
Extend the selection as you go	Add Shift
Nudge later or earlier	+ −
Bigger or smaller grid	Shift = −
Bigger or smaller nudge	Alt Shift = −

Tab to Transient

Turn on Options › Tab to Transient and Tab stops at each hit inside a clip, not only at its edges. It is the quick way to find a drum hit to cut on.

SECTION 4

MIDI & Instruments

Write with notes: the piano roll, the Juke drum machine and its patterns, and the Lift sampler.

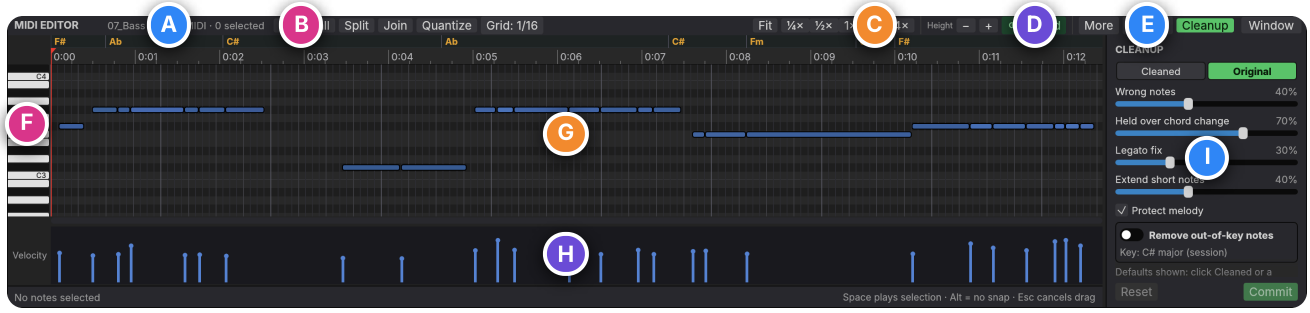
FreeDAWm

FreeDAWm

THE MIDI EDITOR

The Goal

Find your way round the piano roll. Select a MIDI clip and choose Window › MIDI Editor, or click the MIDI Editor tab at the bottom of the Edit window. The next page covers editing.



A — Clip and selection
The clip you are editing and how many notes are selected.

B — Note tools
Select all, Split at the playhead, and Join.

C — Zoom and height
Fit shows the whole clip. ¼× to 4× zoom in time. Height makes the rows taller.

D — Linked
Keeps the editor lined up with the Edit window's timeline.

E — Ghosts
Shows the notes of other MIDI clips faintly, so you can write against them.

F — Piano keys
Each row is one pitch. Click a key to hear it.

G — Notes
Each bar is a note. Higher is higher in pitch, longer lasts longer. Drag to move one.

H — Velocity
How hard each note is played. A taller bar is a louder note.

I — Cleanup
Tidies a played part. Compare Cleaned with Original, then Commit.

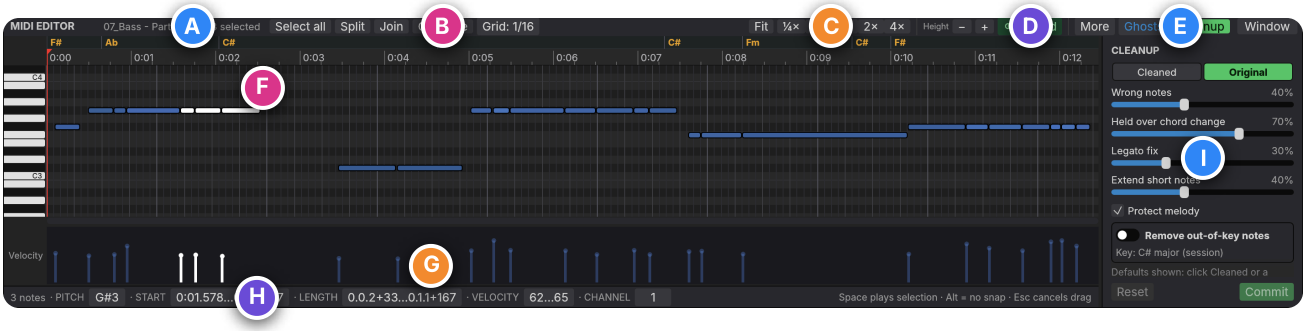
Play the selection	`Space` with the pointer over the notes
Move without snapping	Hold `Alt` while you drag
Cancel a drag	`Esc`
Fit the clip	`F` with the pointer over the notes
Quantize, Transpose	`Alt` `0`, `Alt` `T` (also in the Event menu)

FreeDAWm

EDITING NOTES

The Goal

Change what was played: move, stretch, split and tidy notes, then shape how hard they hit.



A Selection
How many notes are selected, then Select all, Split at the playhead and Join.

B Quantize and Grid
Quantize pulls the selected notes onto the grid. Grid sets the editor's own step, or follows the Edit window.

C Zoom
Fit, then ¼× to 4× of the Edit window's zoom. Height makes the rows taller.

D Linked
Keeps the editor's time lined up with the Edit window.

E Panels
More, Ghosts, Cleanup and Window.

F Selected notes
Selected notes are highlighted. Drag one to move them all.

G Velocity
One bar per note. Drag a bar's top to change how hard the note plays.

H Note bar
Pitch, start, length, velocity and channel of the selection. Double-click a value to type.

I Cleanup
Fixes a part made by Convert to MIDI: wrong notes and notes held over a chord change. It previews until you Commit.

WITH THE MOUSE

Select a note	Click it
Add to the selection	Shift -click
Move in time or pitch	Drag a note

FROM THE EVENT MENU

Quantize	Alt 0
Transpose	Alt T
Change Duration	Alt P

Controller lanes

The Lanes menu adds lanes under velocity for mod wheel, sustain, pitch bend and more. Click to add a point.

FreeDAWm

JUKE: THE KIT

The Goal

Build a beat. Choose Track › New Beat and FreeDAWm makes an instrument track playing Juke, its drum machine, with a first pattern on the timeline. This page is the Kit tab, where you choose and shape the sounds.



A **Pad**
Its name, the key that plays it, and whether it is a sample or a synth voice.

B **Pad menu**
The pencil opens the pad editor. Plus adds a sound. The arrow has copy and clear.

C **Tune and Pan**
Pitch in semitones, and left-right position.

D **Sends**
How much of this pad goes to Bus A and Bus B.

E **Level**
The pad's fader and meter.

F **Play, Choke, S, M**
Audition the pad, solo or mute it. Pads in one choke group cut each other off, as a closed hat cuts an open one.

G **Kits, Presets, Grooves**
Load a whole kit, a preset for it, or a ready-made beat.

H **Randomize and Humanize**
Randomize rolls new sounds. Humanize adds small changes in level and timing.

I **Bus A and Bus B**
Two shared effect chains with four FireStation slots each.

J **Output**
Four more slots on the whole kit. Here Sat adds a little glue.

K **Keys**
Every pad's key. Click one to play it.

FreeDAWm

JUKE: PATTERNS

The Goal

Program the beat on a grid. Each column is a step in the bar and each row is a pad. A lit step plays that pad at that moment.



A — Kit
The kit in use. The arrows step to the next or previous one.

B — Tabs
Kit for the sounds, Pad for one sound in detail, Steps for the pattern.

C — Patterns
Each pattern is a clip on the track. + Pattern adds another, Duplicate copies this one.

D — Steps per bar
8, 12, 16, 24 or 32. Use 12 or 24 for a triplet feel.

E — New steps
How hard a step you add will hit: Full, 75, 50 or 25.

F — Feel
Shuffle delays every second step. Accent sets how much louder an accented step is. Fill every plays a fill each few bars.

G — Re-roll and Convert
Re-roll draws new random variations. Convert to MIDI turns the pattern into ordinary notes.

H — Lanes
One row per pad, with its own length and mute. Lanes of different lengths drift against each other.

I — Steps
Click to turn a step on or off. Drag across to paint. Drag up or down for velocity.

J — Keys
Play the pads while the pattern runs.

Step details	Right-click a step for its chance of playing, a roll of up to four hits, a flam, a nudge early or late, and a rule such as every other bar.
Keys 1 to 4	Set the velocity of new steps: Full, 75, 50, 25.
Same every time	Random choices are fixed per bar, so a pattern plays and bounces the same way each time until you Re-roll.
On the timeline	A pattern clip trims, copies and loops like any clip. Editing its notes in the MIDI Editor turns it into a plain MIDI clip.

FreeDAWm

LIFT: THE SAMPLER

The Goal

Turn any sound into an instrument. Lift plays one sample across the keyboard. Make an Instrument Track, choose Lift as its instrument, and double-click the instrument slot to open this window.



A — Sample
The sample in use. Drop an audio file anywhere on the window to load it.

B — Load and From Selection
Pick a file, or select a range on an audio track and turn it into the sample.

C — Waveform
Drag the markers to set where the sample starts, ends and loops.

D — Trim, Normalize, Reverse
Tidy the sample. Slice cuts it into pieces to play from separate keys.

E — Amp envelope
How each note rises and dies away: Attack, Decay, Sustain, Release.

F — Filter
Low-pass, high-pass or band-pass, with its own envelope.

G — Pitch
Tune, the root note the sample plays back unchanged on, fine tuning and glide.

H — LFO
A slow wave that can move pitch, filter or volume. Sync locks it to the tempo.

I — Output
Pan, and the range of velocities the sample answers to.

J — Playback
Gate plays while the key is held. One-shot plays to the end. Loop, voices and warp to tempo.

SECTION 5

Vocals

Tune a voice note by note, and line up a stack of backing vocals against the lead.

FreeDAWm

FreeDAWm

TUNE A VOCAL

The Goal

Fix the notes that are off without flattening the performance. Select a vocal clip and choose AI › Tune Vocal, or open Window › Vocal Editor. No download is needed, and FreeDAWm analyses vocal tracks in the background.



A — Note tools
Studio, Select all, Split and Join.

B — Preview
Plays a note once, on its own, whenever you click or change it.

C — Zoom
¼× to 4× of the Edit window's zoom. Rows makes the notes taller.

D — Chords and key
What the song is doing above the notes. Set them on the timeline, not here.

E — Notes
Each bar is a sung note, as thick as it is loud. Teal is on pitch, amber is drifting, red is 48 cents out or more.

F — Pitch curve
The wavy line is the voice. White where your edit moved it, dashed where it was.

G — Piano keys
Rows the song's key does not use are hatched.

H — Level lane
How loud each note is against the track's typical level.

I — Tuned / Original
Switch to hear the voice before and after.

J — Sliders
Centre, Drift, Vibrato, Raise quiet and Lower loud. See the next page.

K — Macro
A preset for all the sliders. Apply it to the selection or the whole track.

L — Commit
Makes the tuning permanent. Until then it can be changed or removed.

FreeDAWm

TUNING MOVES

The Goal Start broad and finish by hand: apply a gentle macro to the whole track, then fix the few notes that still stand out.

THE SLIDERS

Centre	Pulls each note's middle toward the right pitch and keeps the singer's vibrato.
Drift	Takes out slow wandering within a note.
Vibrato	Less or more of the natural wobble.
Raise quiet, Lower loud	Evens out the level, toward the track's typical level.
Snap to key	Moves notes onto the nearest note of the song's key. Needs a key set on the timeline.

BY HAND

Move a note's pitch	Drag it up or down
Move without snapping	Hold Alt
Up or down a semitone	Alt ↑ Alt ↓
Split a note	S at the pointer
Join two notes	J
Cancel a drag	Esc

SELECT AND LISTEN

Select all notes	Cmd A
Only the notes in view	Cmd Shift A
Add to the selection	Shift-click
Play the selection	Space
Play from the playhead	Shift Space
Clear the selection	Esc

Note bar	Under the selected note: cents, semitones, drift, vibrato and level. Drag a value sideways or double-click to type.
Scoops	Where the voice slides into a note there is a handle: Keep, Smooth or Shorten the slide.
Vocal tracks	Tracks named like Vox or BGV are marked as vocal and analysed for you. Track › Vocal Track sets it by hand.
In the mixer	Each vocal strip has a pitch box with the current note, plus Centre note and Flatten drift buttons.
Limits	Tuning changes pitch and level, not timing. A stretched clip plays untuned. Commit before you Consolidate.

FreeDAWm

THE VOCAL STUDIO

The Goal

See every vocal part on one piano roll, so backing vocals can be tuned against the lead and against each other. Open it with Window › Vocal Studio, or the Studio button in the Vocal Editor.



A — All vocals and Edit
Show or hide the other parts, and choose the part you are editing.

B — Against
The part the others are checked against, usually the lead. Tolerance sets how far apart counts as a clash.

C — Tune all
Tunes every shown part in one go.

D — Make harmony
Writes a new part from the lead: a third up, in key, following the chords.

E — Tracks
Each part with its status, an eye to hide it, and solo and mute. Click a name to edit that part.

F — Reference notes
The other parts, faint, each in its own colour. Double-click one to edit its track.

G — Editing notes
The part you are working on, in full colour, with every Vocal Editor tool.

H — Clash
A red ! marks a note that clashes with the lead.

I — Stack
Striped notes are two parts on one note. Click the 2 badge to pick one, or to match one to the other.

J — Editor view
Back to the single-track Vocal Editor.

Edit All	Choose All under Edit to work on every shown part at once. A note never changes track.
Fit to lead	Lines a backing part up with the lead's pitch where they sing the same note.
Harmony preview	Make harmony draws the planned notes as dashed outlines before you create the part.

SECTION 6

Mixing

Balance the tracks, shape each sound with the FireStation effects, share one reverb between many tracks, and make the mix move with automation.

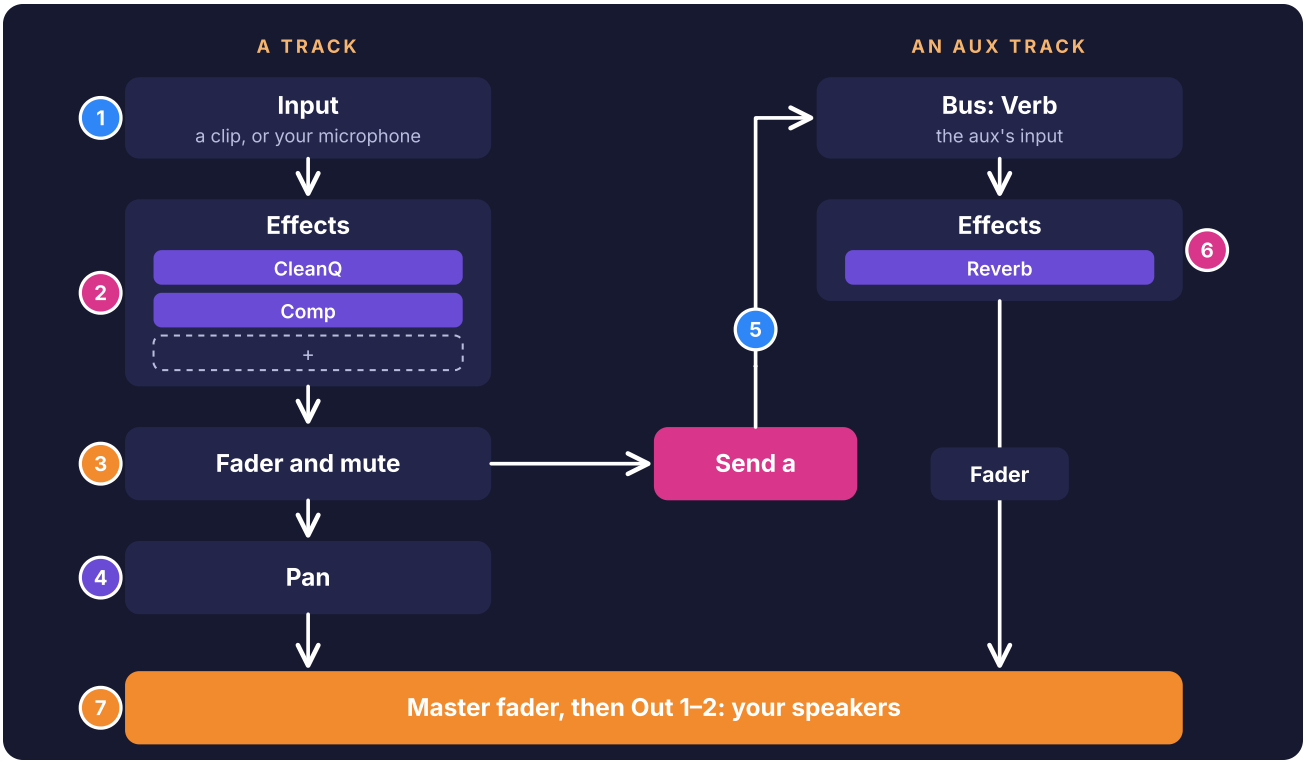
FreeDAWm

FreeDAWm

SIGNAL FLOW

The Goal

Know the path sound takes through the mixer. Once you can trace it, you can work out why a change did or did not do what you expected.



1. **Input**
   What the track plays: its clips, or the live input while you record.
2. **Effects**
   Processed in order from the top. Swap two and the sound changes.
3. **Fader and mute**
   Sets the track's level after the effects have done their work.
4. **Pan**
   Places the track between the left and right speakers.
5. **Send**
   A copy of the track, taken after the fader, on its way to a bus.
6. **Aux track**
   Listens to the bus and adds its own effects, here one reverb for every track that sends to it.
7. **Master**
   Every track and aux ends up here. Its fader sets the level of the whole mix.

Try this

A compressor sits before the fader, so turning the fader down does not change how hard it works. To drive it harder or softer, change the level before it: the clip's gain or the effect's own input.

FreeDAWm

ADD AN EFFECT

The Goal

Put an effect on a track. In the Mix window each effect is a tile at the top of the strip, and an empty slot is a dashed box with a plus. A strip holds up to 32, in any order.



A — Empty slot
Click the plus to open the list of effects.

B — Search
Type part of a name, such as comp or verb.

C — FireStation
The eighteen studio effects built into FreeDAWm. Page 32 says what each one is for.

D — Utilities
Small tools: Gain, Trim, Invert, DC Offset Removal, Time Shift and Signal Generator.

E — Scan plugins
Finds the CLAP, VST3 and Audio Units plugins installed on your computer and adds them to this list.

F — On light
Green means the module is working. Click it to bypass.

G — Open
The arrow opens the module's full editor in its own window.

H — Quick knobs
The controls you reach for most, with a live graph above them.

THREE HABITS

1 — Listen in the mix
Adjust an effect with the whole song playing, not with the track soloed. What matters is how it sits with the rest.

2 — Match the level
Louder nearly always sounds better. Compare with the effect off at the same loudness before you decide.

3 — Mind the order
Modules run top to bottom. Drag a tile to move it, and its automation moves with it.

Running slow?

The snowflake on a strip freezes the track. FreeDAWm plays a rendered copy and the effects stop using the computer. Click it again to unfreeze and carry on editing.

FreeDAWm

INSIDE AN EFFECT

The Goal

Every FireStation module opens the same way and shares the same top bar. Learn it once on Comp, shown here, and the other seventeen will feel familiar.



A **The tile**
Click a tile and its editor opens in place, beside the strip. Click again to fold it away.

B **Presets**
Step through the factory presets with the arrows, or click the name for the full list.

C **Compare**
Undo, two settings to switch between (1 and 2), and Bypass.

D **Styles**
Comp has ten compressor styles. The line underneath says what the chosen one is like.

E **Meter**
How much the compressor is turning the sound down right now.

F **Curve**
Input level along the bottom, output level up the side. The bend is the threshold.

G **Lanes**
Run up to three styles side by side, by frequency band or one after another, with a dry fader.

H **Main controls**
Threshold, Ratio, Attack, Release and Makeup. Drag a knob, or double-click its value to type.

I **Auto gain**
Keeps the loudness the same as you adjust, so you judge the sound and not the level.

Slim or full editors	View › Mix Window Views › Slim Plugin Editors swaps each editor for a narrow version with the same controls.
Slim or wide strips	The Channel width bar above the strips: Slim, Wide or Auto, for the selected channels or all of them.
A window of its own	The arrow on a tile opens the full editor as a floating window you can leave open.
Sidechain	A module can listen to another track, such as a compressor on the bass that ducks when the kick hits.

FreeDAWm

THE FIRESTATION EFFECTS

The Goal

Match the problem you hear to the module that fixes it. These eighteen come with FreeDAWm and are the only effects in the menu until you scan your own plugins.

MODULE	WHAT IT IS	REACH FOR IT WHEN
CleanQ	Dynamic EQ with up to 24 bands, and a ceiling you can draw or let it learn.	**Tone: muddy, harsh, boomy or dull.**
Vint	Vintage EQ and colour boxes, seven circuits.	**Broad, musical tone shaping.**
Filter	Envelope and auto filters, moved by hand, by the sound, by an LFO or in steps.	**Sweeps and wah.**
Comp	Compressor with ten styles in three lanes: parallel, multiband or serial.	**Uneven level. Glue on a bus.**
Transient	Shapes the attack and sustain of any sound.	**Drums that are too soft or too spiky.**
Shale	Drum gate with lookahead and bleed removal. Can trigger a MIDI note per hit.	**Spill between drum mics.**
Swale	Automatic volume swells.	**Fading notes in, like a bowed string.**
Sat	Tube, transformer and tape-style saturation.	**Sounds that are too clean.**
Tape	Tape machine: saturation, compression, wow and flutter, head bump.	**Warmth and gentle glue.**
Dist	Twelve drive, overdrive and fuzz pedal circuits.	**Grit, from a little to a lot.**
Amp	Seven tube amps with built-in or impulse-response cabinets.	**Guitars and bass recorded direct.**
Mod	Fourteen circuits: choruses, flangers, phasers, tremolos, vibratos.	**Width and movement.**
Pitch	Octaver, harmonizer and whammy effects.	**Extra octaves and harmonies.**
Delay	Six voicings from digital to tape, synced to the tempo, with freeze and reverse.	**Echoes.**
Reverb	Room, hall, plate, spring, cloud and shimmer.	**Putting a sound in a space.**
ChamberMade	A reverb chamber you build: room, materials, speaker and mic placement.	**A space of your own design.**
Twine	Mastering clipper and true-peak limiter.	**Loudness on the master.**
LevelUp	Loudness-matched A/B, reference tracks, delivery metering and dither.	**Checking the finished mix.**

Good to know

Where a mode models a piece of hardware, the editor says so. To tune a voice, use AI › Tune Vocal, not Pitch. See page 25.

FreeDAWm

THE PLUGIN BROWSER

The Goal

Browse everything you can put on a track, by picture. Open it with Window › Plugin Browser, Alt B, or the Plugin Browser tab at the bottom right of the Edit window.



A **Type**
Instruments, Effects or Presets.

B **View**
Switch between cards and a compact list.

C **Search**
Looks in names, vendors and categories.

D **Filters**
Favourites, Recent, then categories such as EQ, Dynamics and Reverb.

E **Vendor**
Show one maker's plugins.

F **Scan plugins**
Adds the CLAP, VST3 and Audio Units plugins on your computer.

G **Card**
A picture of the plugin's own window. Drag it onto a track or an effect slot.

H **Name and maker**
Click the star on a card to keep it under Favourites.

Drag and drop

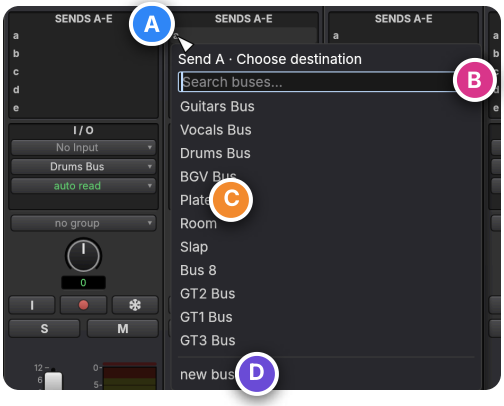
Drag a card onto a strip's empty slot to add it there, onto an existing tile to replace it, or onto a track in the Edit window. A preset for a hosted plugin loads in place.

FreeDAWm

SENDS & SHARED REVERB

The Goal

Put several tracks in the same room. One reverb on an aux track, fed by a send from each track, sounds more natural than a separate reverb on every track and is lighter on the computer.



A — Send slots
Each strip has slots a to e. Click an empty one to open this menu.

B — Search
Type to find a bus when you have many.

C — A bus
Choose where the copy goes. Plate is this song's reverb bus, which the lead vocal sends to.

D — New bus
Makes a new path if the one you want does not exist yet.

BUILD ONE FROM NOTHING

1. **Make an aux track**
Track › New, and choose Aux Input for the track type. Name it after its job, such as Verb.

2. **Give it a bus**
In the aux's I/O section, set its input to a bus. Make a new one if you need to.

3. **Add the reverb**
Click the plus at the top of the aux strip and choose Reverb or ChamberMade. Set it fully wet, since the dry sound comes from the tracks themselves.

4. **Send to it**
On each track, click a send slot and choose the same bus. Raise the send level until you can hear the room.

Good to know

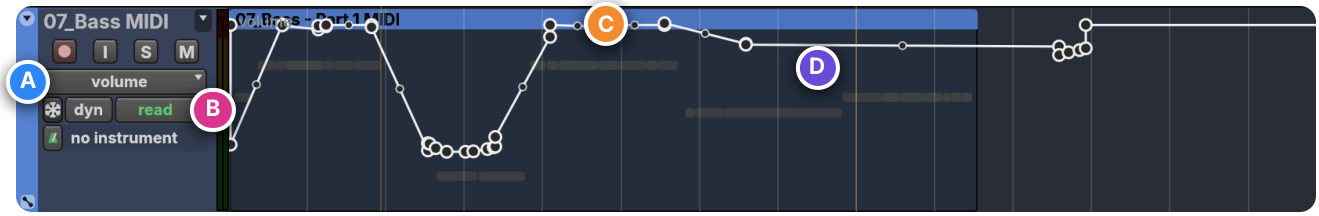
A send follows the track's fader. Turn a track down and less of it reaches the reverb, so the balance between dry and wet stays the same.

FreeDAWm

AUTOMATION

The Goal

Make the mix change over time: a vocal that comes up in the chorus, a pad that fades in. Automation is a line you draw on the track, and FreeDAWm moves the control along it.



A **Track view**
Change waveform to volume, pan or mute to see that control's line over the clips.

B **Automation mode**
Decides whether the track follows the line, ignores it or records your moves.

C **Breakpoints**
The line bends at each point. Drag a point to move it.

D **The line**
Higher is louder. Here the bass drops out for two bars, then comes back.

TWO WAYS TO WRITE IT

Draw it. Show the volume view, then double-click the line with the Grabber or the Smart Tool to add a point. Use the Pencil to draw a shape freehand.

Perform it. Set the mode to touch, press play and move the fader. FreeDAWm records the move and returns to the old line when you let go.

off	Ignores the line. The fader stays wherever you put it.
read	Follows the line. This is the mode tracks start in.
touch	Records while you hold a control, then goes back to the line.
latch	Records from the moment you touch a control, and holds your last value until you stop.
write	Records over everything while the song plays. Switch back to read when you finish.
trim	Raises or lowers the whole existing line without redrawing its shape.

SECTION 7

AI Tools

Separate a mix into its parts, turn audio into notes, chords and lyrics, and generate new material, all on your own computer.

FreeDAWm

FreeDAWm

THE AI MENU

The Goal

Know what each AI tool does and where its result lands. They all run on your own computer. Nothing is uploaded, and each result is one step you can undo.

TOOL	WHAT IT DOES	WHERE IT LANDS
Separate Stems	Splits a mix into drums, bass, vocals and other, or six stems with guitar and piano.	**New audio tracks**
Make Karaoke	Separates the lead vocal from the backing.	**Two new tracks**
Split Drums	Splits a drum recording into kick, snare, toms, hi-hat, ride and crash.	**New audio tracks**
Clean Vocal	Removes noise and room reverb from a voice, with an Amount control.	**The same clip, switchable**
Tune Vocal	Note-based pitch and level correction. See page 25.	**The same clip, switchable**
Convert to MIDI	Turns audio into notes. Models for general use, piano, drums and vocals.	**A new instrument track**
Detect Chords	Works out the chords of a recording.	**The Chords ruler**
Transcribe Lyrics	Writes down the sung words with their timings.	**The Lyrics ruler**
MIDI Cleanup	Tidies a transcribed piano part. See page 20.	**The same clip**
Generate MIDI from Text	Describe the music and get a part per instrument.	**New instrument tracks**
Generate Song	Makes a whole song with vocals from style tags and lyrics.	**A new audio track**

First

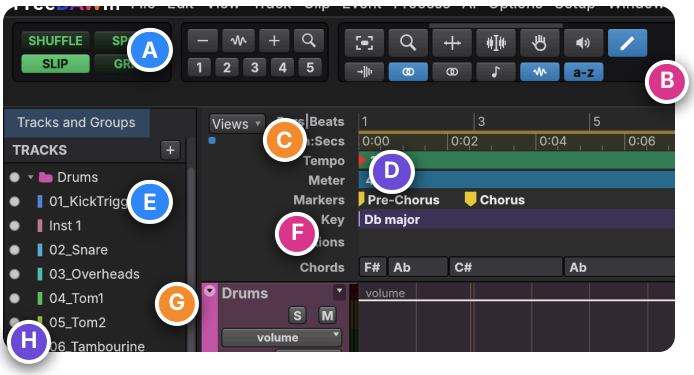
Select an audio clip or track first. Most of the menu is greyed out until you do. Generate MIDI from Text and Generate Song need no selection.

FreeDAWm

RUN AN AI TOOL

The Goal

Every AI tool opens a small dialog like this one. Separate Stems is shown, and the others follow the same order: source, choices, where it runs, then Run.



A **Source**
The track or clip you selected.

B **Model**
Best of each takes each stem from the model that does it best. The others are faster or split differently.

C **Stems**
Tick the parts you want as new tracks.

D **Quality**
High takes about twice as long.

E **Mute original**
Silences the source so you hear only the stems.

F **Run on**
The graphics card when there is one, else the processor.

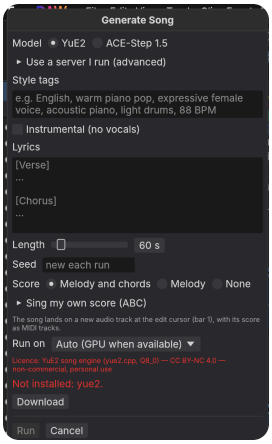
G **Download**
Shown when the model is not installed yet. Click it once.

H **Run**
Starts the job. A progress window lets you cancel.

TWO MORE



Convert to MIDI. Pick a model for the instrument. Isolate first separates that instrument before reading its notes. Analyse lets you audition the result before you commit.



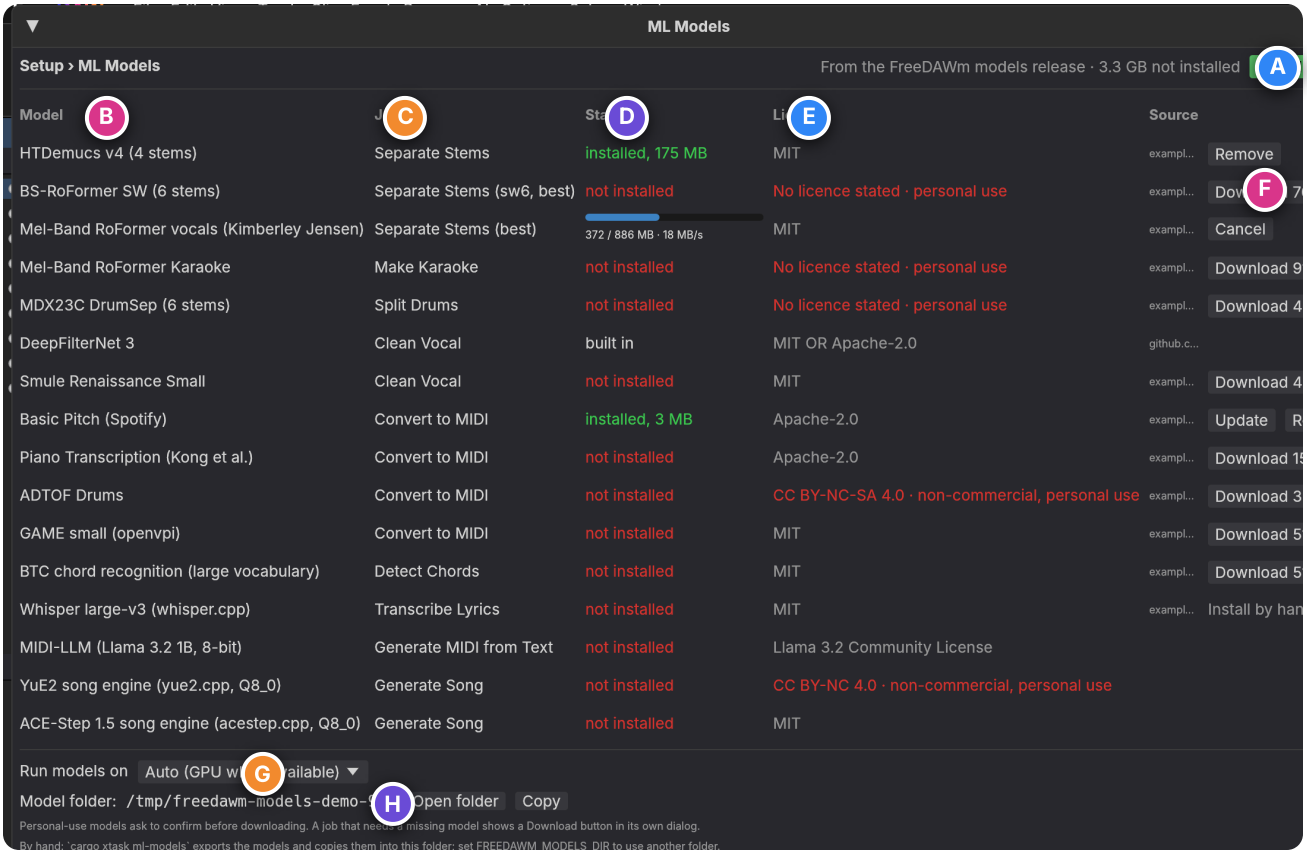
Generate Song. Describe the style, add lyrics under [Verse] and [Chorus] headings, and set a length. The same seed makes the same song again.

FreeDAWm

SET UP THE AI MODELS

The Goal

The AI tools need model files that are not shipped with FreeDAWm. Download the ones you want once, in Setup › ML Models. Clean Vocal's noise removal and Tune Vocal work without any download.



A **Download all**
Fetches every model you do not have yet.

B **Model**
One row per model.

C **Job**
The AI menu item that uses it.

D **Status**
Installed, not installed, or downloading with a progress bar.

E **Licence**
Red means personal, non-commercial use only, or no licence stated by its author.

F **Download**
Fetch one model. Remove deletes it again.

G **Run models on**
The graphics card when available, or the processor.

H **Model folder**
Where the files are kept. Open folder shows it.

Check first

Read the Licence column before you use a result in music you sell. Some models are for personal use only, and FreeDAWm asks you to confirm before downloading those.

SECTION 8

Finishing

Turn the session into a file people can play, send the separate parts to someone else, and take your work to another program.

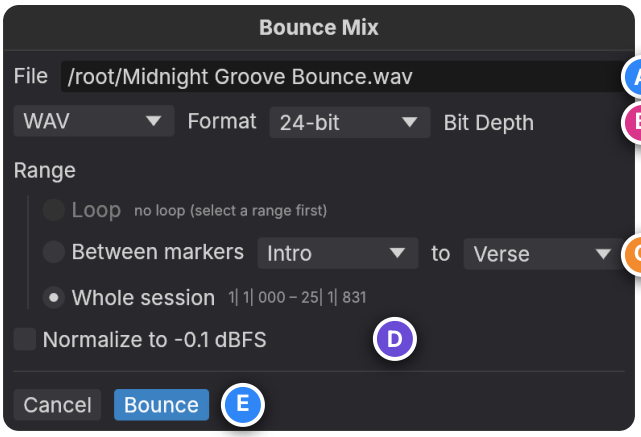
FreeDAWm

FreeDAWm

BOUNCE THE MIX

The Goal

Make one audio file of the whole mix, the file you share or upload. Choose File › Bounce Mix, or press Cmd Alt B.



A **File**
Where the file is saved and what it is called.

B **Format and bit depth**
The kind of file and its quality. See the table below.

C **Range**
The loop, the stretch between two markers, or the whole session.

D **Normalize**
Raises the finished file so its loudest moment sits just under the limit.

E **Bounce**
Writes the file.

WHICH FORMAT?

WAV or AIFF	Full quality, large files. Use these for mastering, for distribution services, and to keep as your own copy.
FLAC	Full quality at about half the size. Good for archiving and sending.
MP3 or Opus	Small files that lose a little quality. Use these for email, messages and quick listens.

WHICH BIT DEPTH?

16-bit	The CD standard. Fine for a finished song.
24-bit	The usual choice, and what to send to a mastering engineer.
32-bit float	Cannot clip. Use it for a mix you will keep working on elsewhere.

Before you bounce

Listen to the whole song once and watch the master meter. If it reaches the red, pull the master fader down and bounce again.

FreeDAWm

OTHER WAYS OUT

The Goal Get more than one stereo file out of a session: the separate parts for a collaborator, the notes for another program, or the whole project.

YOU WANT	WHAT YOU GET	WHERE
Stems	One audio file per track, all the same length, so someone else can remix or master from the parts.	**File › Export › Stems**
Clips	The selected clips as separate audio files, for samples or sound effects.	**File › Export › Clips**
The notes	A MIDI file of your MIDI and instrument parts, to open in any other music program.	**File › Export › MIDI**
The project	A DAWproject file, an open format that other workstations can read, with tracks and clips in place.	**File › Export › DAWproject**
Some tracks	A new session holding only the tracks you selected.	**File › Export › Selected Tracks as New Session**
The words	The lyrics as plain text, or as an LRC file with timings for players that show lyrics.	**File › Export › Lyrics**
One track	A track rendered to audio with its effects, back in the session.	**Track › Bounce or Track › Commit**
A backup	A full copy of the session in another place.	**File › Save Session Copy In**

Coming in The same menu works the other way. File › Import brings in audio, MIDI, video, DAWproject files and the tracks of another session.

SECTION 9

Menu Map

Every menu in the menu bar, group by group, so you can find a command by where it lives.

FreeDAWm

FreeDAWm

FREEDAWM, FILE & SETUP

FreeDAWm

About the app, facts about the session, and Quit.

About FreeDAWm
Session Info
Session Audio Health
Quit

File

Sessions: make, open, save, and bring things in or send them out.

SESSION

New... Cmd N
New from Template...
Open › Session..., Open Recent
Close Session Cmd Shift W

SAVE

Save Session Cmd S
Save Session As... Cmd Shift S
Save Session Copy In...
Save As Template...
Revert Session to Saved...

BRING IN & SEND OUT

Bounce Mix... Cmd Alt B
Import › Session Data..., Audio..., MIDI..., Video..., Clip Groups..., DAWproject..., Reference..., FireStation User Presets
Export › MIDI..., Sibelius..., Lyrics (LRC)..., Lyrics as Text..., Session Info as Text..., Selected Tracks as New Session..., DAWproject..., Stems..., Clips..., Clip Groups...

SCORE

Score Setup...
Print Score... Cmd P

Setup

Your audio device, inputs, shortcuts, preferences and AI models.

AUDIO

Playback Engine...
I/O...

RECORDING & MIDI

Click/Countoff... (coming soon)
MIDI Input Devices...
Network...

SESSION & KEYS

Session Cmd 2
Keyboard Shortcuts...
Preferences...

AI

ML Models...

EDIT MENU

Edit

Everything you do to the selection: clipboard, cuts, fades, trims and automation.

UNDO

Undo
Redo
Restore Last Selection — Cmd Alt Z

CLIPBOARD

Cut — Cmd X
Copy — Cmd C
Paste — Cmd V
Clear — Cmd B
Duplicate — Cmd D
Repeat... — Alt R
Special › Cut Special › Clip Gain, Clip Effects, All Automation, Pan Automation, Plugin Automation
Special › Copy Special › Clip Gain, Clip Effects, All Automation, Pan Automation, Plugin Automation, Audio as MIDI
Special › Paste Special › Merge MIDI, Merge Markers, Repeat to Fill Selection, To Current Automation Type
Special › Clear Special › Clip Gain, Clip Effects, All Automation, Pan Automation, Plugin Automation

SELECT

Select All — Cmd A
Select Loop Range — Ctrl Alt L
Clear Loop
Selection › Change Timeline to Match Edit, Change Edit to Match Timeline, Play Edit, Play Timeline, Move Edit Left, Move Edit Right, Halve Edit, Double Edit, Duplicate and Extend Edit, Extend Edit Up, Extend Edit Down, and 8 more

CLIP EDITING

Separate › At Selection, On Grid, At Transients
Heal Separation — Cmd H
Consolidate — Alt Shift 3
Split into Files
Mute — Cmd M
Strip Silence — Cmd U
Shift... — Alt H
Fades › Create..., Delete, Fade to Start, Fade to End

TRIM

Trim › To Selection, Start to Insertion, End to Insertion, To Fill Selection, To File Boundaries

PLAYLISTS

Copy Selection to... › Target Playlist, New Playlist, Duplicate of Main Playlist
Move Selection to... › Target Playlist, New Playlist, Duplicate of Main Playlist

AUTOMATION

Automation › Write to Current, Write to All Enabled, Trim to All Enabled, Glide to All Enabled, Glide Pan Only, Thin, Thin All, Convert Volume Automation to Clip Gain, Convert Clip Gain to Volume Automation, Coalesce Volume Automation to Clip Gain, Coalesce Clip Gain to Volume Automation, Copy to Send
More › Space Clips, Insert Silence, Snap to Next, Snap to Previous, TCE Edit to Timeline Selection

FreeDAWm

VIEW & CLIP

View

What the windows show: rulers, counters, clip details and mixer sections.

TIMELINE

Rulers › Bars|Beats, Min:Secs, Timecode, Timecode 2, Feet+Frames, Samples, Tempo, Tempo Editor, Meter, Key Signature, Sections, and 11 more

Main Counter › Bars|Beats, Min:Secs, Timecode, Feet+Frames, Samples

Track Number

EDIT WINDOW

Edit Window Views › Comments, Instruments, Inserts A-E, Inserts F-J, Sends A-E, Sends F-J, I/O, All, Minimal

Clip › Name, Sync Point, Rating, Clip Gain Line, Clip Gain Info, Clip Effects Status, Transparency, Overlap Shadows, Current Time, Original Time Stamp, User Time Stamp, No Time

Waveforms › Peak, Power, Rectified, Outlines, Overlapped Crossfades

MIX WINDOW

Mix Window Views › Mic Preamps, Instruments, Inserts A-E, Inserts F-J, Sends A-E, Sends F-J, I/O, Object, Pitch, Track Color, Comments, and 4 more

Narrow Mix — Cmd Alt M

Channel Width › Slim, Wide, Auto, All Slim, All Wide, All Auto

Expanded Sends › None, All, Send A, Send B, Send C, Send D, Send E, Send F, Send G, Send H, Send I, Send J

TRANSPORT

Transport › Counters, MIDI Controls, Output Meters, Expanded

Clip

Act on the selected clips: group, lock, loop, gain and timing.

CREATE

New MIDI Clip

New Pattern

Convert Pattern to MIDI

Capture — Cmd R

Rename... — Cmd Alt Shift R

Loop — Cmd Alt L

Unloop

ORDER & GROUPS

Send to Back — Alt Shift B

Bring to Front — Alt Shift F

Group — Cmd Alt G

Ungroup — Cmd Alt U

Ungroup All

Regroup — Cmd Alt R

LOCK & RATE

Edit Lock/Unlock — Cmd L

Time Lock/Unlock — Ctrl Alt L

Rating › none, 1, 2, 3, 4, 5

GAIN & EFFECTS

Clip Gain › Bypass, Render

Clip Effects › Bypass, Render

TIMING & PITCH

Quantize to Grid — Cmd 0

Conform to Tempo

Identify Sync Point

Elastic Properties — Alt 5

Remove › Sync Point, Warp, Pitch Shift

TRACK MENU

Track

Make, organise, freeze and route tracks.

CREATE

- New... Cmd Shift N
- Duplicate Alt Shift D
- Create Click Track
- New Beat

ORGANISE

- Rename...
- Color...
- Group... Cmd G
- Move to New Folder Cmd Alt Shift N
- Convert Aux to Routing Folder
- Hide
- Vocal Track
- Make Inactive
- Delete

CHANNELS

- Change Track Width › Mono, Stereo, LCR, Quad, 5.1, 7.1
- Change Track Width › More › LCRS, 5.0, 6.0, 6.1, 7.0, 7.0 SDDS, 7.1 SDDS, 5.0.2, 5.1.2, 7.0.2, 7.1.2, and 17 more
- Split into Mono
- Instrument

FREEZE & RENDER

- Freeze
- Commit Alt Shift C
- Bounce Cmd Alt Shift B
- Extract MIDI to New Track

INSERTS & SENDS

- Bypass Inserts › All, Inserts A-E, Inserts F-J, EQ, Dynamics, Reverb, Delay, Modulation
- Mute Sends › All, Sends A-E, Sends F-J
- Save Track Preset...
- Load Track Preset...

PLAYLISTS

- New Playlist
- Designate as Target Playlist Cmd Shift Right
- Show Target Playlist Shift Right
- Toggle Recent Playlist Ctrl Alt Shift Left
- More › Write MIDI Real-Time Properties, Set Record Tracks to Input Only, Clear All Clip Indicators, Coalesce VCA Controller Automation, Coalesce Trim Automation, Clear Trim Automation

FreeDAWm

EVENT & OPTIONS

Event

Time, tempo and MIDI operations.

TIME & TEMPO

Time Operations › Time Operations Window, Change Meter... (coming soon), Insert Time, Cut Time
Tempo Operations Window
Add Key Change... (coming soon)

MIDI EDITING

MIDI Operations Window
Quantize... Alt 0
Transpose... Alt T
Change Duration Alt P
Remove Duplicate Notes
Snap Notes to Scale
More MIDI › Change Velocity..., Select/Split Notes, Input Quantize, Step Input, Restore Performance, Flatten Performance, MIDI Track Offsets, MIDI Real-Time Properties

ANALYSE

Detect Tempo...
Beat Detective
Identify Beat Cmd I
Extract Chords from Selection

PANIC

All MIDI Notes Off Cmd Shift .

Options

Switches for how recording, playback and editing behave.

RECORDING & PLAYBACK

Click
Loop Playback Cmd Shift L
Loop Record Alt L
Pre/Post-Roll... Cmd K
Low Latency Monitoring
Video Track Online

FOLLOWING & LINKING

Link Timeline and Edit Selection Shift /
Insertion Follows Playback
Automation Follows Edit
Tab to Transient Cmd Alt Tab

SCROLLING & SOLO

Edit Window Scrolling › No Scrolling, After Playback, Page, Continuous, Center Playhead
Solo Mode › SIP (Solo In Place), X-OR (Cancels Previous Solo)

TIMING & KEYS

Delay Compensation
Edit/Tool Mode Keyboard Lock
More › Prepare DPE Tracks

PROCESS & AI

Process

Offline processing: the effect is written into the selected audio.

TONE

EQ › Channel Strip, EQ 1-Band, EQ 7-Band
Dynamics › FET Compressor, De-Esser, Expander / Gate, Maximizer

TIME & PITCH

Pitch Shift › Pitch Shift, Time Shift, Speed Ramp

SPACE & COLOUR

Room Reverb
Mod Delay
Ring Mod
Guitar Amp
Bit Crusher
Rectifier

UTILITIES

Normalize
Gain
Reverse
Invert
More › DC Offset Removal, Duplicate, Signal Generator

AI

Tools that run on your computer. See Section 7.

SEPARATE

Separate Stems...
Make Karaoke...
Split Drums...

CLEAN

Clean Vocal...
Clean Vocal › Original / Cleaned, Amount..., Commit, Remove Cleaned Version
Tune Vocal...
Tune Vocal › Analyse Now, Tuned / Original, Notes Classic / Musical, Fit to Lead, Make Harmony..., Commit, Remove Tuning

TRANSCRIBE

Convert to MIDI...
Detect Chords...
Transcribe Lyrics...
MIDI Cleanup...

GENERATE

Generate MIDI from Text...
Generate Song...

WINDOW MENU

Window

Open the windows, editors and panels, and arrange them.

MAIN WINDOWS

- Mix — Cmd =
- Edit — Cmd =
- Mix in Separate Window
- Vocal Editor in Separate Window
- Teleprompter in Separate Window
- MIDI Editor in Separate Window
- Sync › Sync Selection, Scroll to Selected Track, Follow Folder Collapse, Sync Track Visibility

EDITORS

- MIDI Editor
- Vocal Editor
- Vocal Studio
- Score Editor — Cmd Ctrl =
- MIDI Event List — Alt =
- Musical Typing — Shift K

TRANSPORT & SESSION

- Transport — Cmd 1
- Big Counter — Cmd 3
- Memory Locations — Cmd 5
- Notes
- Lyrics
- Teleprompter
- Automation — Cmd 4

PANELS & BROWSERS

- Clip List
- Track List
- Clip Effects
- Plugin Browser — Alt B
- Workspace Browser — Alt I
- Undo History

BAND & CAPTURE

- Studio
- Scout

LAYOUT

- Configurations › Window Configuration List, New Configuration, Update Active Configuration, Auto-Update Active Configuration
- Tile
- Reset Panel Layout
- Close Floating Windows — Cmd W
- More › Video, Video Universe, Universe, Search, Renderer, Metadata Inspector, Color Palette, UI Customization, Task Manager, Disk Usage, System Usage, Close All Workspaces

GLOSSARY

Aux track
A track with no clips of its own. It takes sound from a bus, usually to hold an effect that several tracks share.

Automation
A line on a track that moves a control, such as volume, as the song plays.

Bounce
To write the mix, or one track, out as an audio file.

Buffer size
How much sound the computer handles in one go. Small means less delay, large means steadier playback.

Bus
A path inside FreeDAWm that carries sound from one or more tracks to another place.

Clip
One piece of audio or MIDI on the timeline. Editing a clip does not change the recording behind it.

Comp
One good take assembled from the best parts of several.

Compressor
An effect that turns down the loud moments so a part sits at a steadier level.

Count-off
Bars of click played before recording starts, to give you the tempo.

Crossfade
One clip fading out while the next fades in, to hide the join.

DAW
Digital audio workstation: a program for recording, editing and mixing music.

dB
Decibel, the unit of level. A fader at 0 dB leaves the level unchanged.

EQ
Equaliser. It turns ranges of a sound up or down, from bass to treble.

Fade
A ramp in level at the start or end of a clip.

Fader
The slider that sets a track's level in the mix.

Freeze
To swap a track's effects for a rendered copy, so they stop using the computer.

Grid
The steps that clips and selections snap to in Grid mode, such as a sixteenth note.

Input monitoring
Hearing a track's live input through FreeDAWm while you play.

Insert
An effect placed directly on a track.

Latency
The delay between playing a note and hearing it.

Marker
A named point on the timeline, such as Verse or Chorus.

Master
The last fader in the mixer. Everything passes through it.

GLOSSARY

MIDI
Notes and performance data, not sound. An instrument turns it into sound.

Mono and stereo
Mono is one channel. Stereo is two, left and right.

Nudge
To move a clip or selection by a small fixed step.

Pan
A track's position between the left and right speakers.

Playlist
One version of a track's clips. A track can hold several, such as one per take.

Plugin
An effect or instrument, built in or installed separately.

Pre-roll
Playback that starts a little before the point you want, to lead you in.

Punch in
To record over one part of a take and leave the rest.

Quantize
To pull notes or clips onto the grid.

Record enable
To arm a track so that pressing Record captures to it.

Reverb
An effect that adds the sound of a room or hall.

Sample rate
How many times a second the sound is measured. 48 000 Hz is common.

Send
A copy of a track's sound routed to a bus, with its own level.

Session
A FreeDAWm project: its tracks, clips, mix and settings.

Solo
To hear one track by silencing the others.

Stem
One part of a mix exported as its own file.

Take
One recorded attempt at a part.

Tempo
The speed of the song, in beats per minute.

Track
One lane in the session, with its own clips and its own strip in the mixer.

Transient
The sharp start of a sound, such as a drum hit.

Transport
The play, stop and record controls.

Velocity
How hard a MIDI note is played.